I told myself: After Rehabber Kooks, they all want a go at me. She'd scored a direct hit, and now her competitors are lining up to be next.

When will it end?

I reassured myself that the editor had nothing, that he was just fishing. He must've heard a rumor and he was tracking it down. Stay the course, I told myself, and then I told the courtier to call the journalist's bluff, vigorously refute the claim, turn down the deal. Above all, reject the proffered meeting.

I'm not going to submit to blackmail.

The courtier nodded. Done.

Of course…I *had* been doing cocaine around this time. At someone's country house, during a shooting weekend, I'd been offered a line, and I'd done a few more since. It wasn't much fun, and it didn't make me particularly happy, as it seemed to make everyone around me, but it did make me feel *different*, and that was the main goal. Feel. Different. I was a deeply unhappy seventeen-year-old boy willing to try almost anything that would alter the status quo.

That was what I told myself anyway. Back then, I could lie to myself as effortlessly as I'd lied to that courtier.

But now I realized coke hadn't been worth the candle. The risk far outweighed the reward. Threatened with exposure, faced with the prospect of fouling up Granny's Golden Jubilee, walking a knife's edge with the mad press—nothing was worth any of that.

On the bright side, I'd played the game well. After I'd called the journalist's bluff, he went silent. As suspected, he had no photo, and when his con game didn't work, he slithered off. (Or not quite. He slithered into Clarence House, and became very good friends with Camilla and Pa.) I was ashamed for lying. But also proud. In a tight spot, a hugely scary crisis, I hadn't felt any serenity, like Granny, but at least I'd managed to project it. I'd channeled *some* of her superpower, her heroic stoicism. I regretted giving the courtier a cock-and-bull story, but the alternative would've been ten times worse.

So…job well done?

Maybe I wasn't a foundling after all.

37.